

Healthy Living 9

A discussion-based approach to
building healthy relationships

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Getting from Here to There

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.13 analyze the role of alcohol in the decision-making process related to increased risk of unintended pregnancies, STIs, impaired driving and injury.
- 9.14 practice speaking about concerns regarding substance use and gambling in self or others.

Note

- The leading cause of death for 15-25 year olds in Canada is motor vehicle accidents and alcohol is involved in 50% of those. 87% of the drivers in these fatal accidents are male. Youth 15-25 are both the least likely to drive after drinking and the most likely to die when they do. More than double (4% to 9%) the number of youth who report having driven drunk have reported driving high (Chamberlain & Soloman, 2006).

Topic

Impaired driving, decision-making

Materials

- Sets of 5-6 chairs
- 2 pairs of pyjama pants

Background

- Arrange chairs in 4 rectangular groups of 5 or 6, as if cars at a 4 way stop.
- Assign students to “cars” so that all seats are filled. Improvise extra spaces using the trunk and/or two in the front seat if needed.
- Check in question: What is something you’re looking forward to doing in the next 6 months?

Activity A

Begin by describing a scenario using one of the cars. Assign a driver who is going home after a few drinks at 3 a.m. with a car full of friends. There is a crash. Describe the injuries of each individual in the car, including head injury, spinal cord injury and broken bones. The driver walks away from the scene.

Assign one of the cars, including the car previously used for the injuries scenario, to each of the following role plays:

- Passengers are loud and obnoxious to the point they irritate and distract the driver (passengers could be fighting, singing loudly, showing phone to the driver, the driver could be texting). Role-play this for 30 seconds and encourage the driver to find a way to end the distractions however s/he can.
- The second car is full of people who have been drinking, including the driver. Though the driver is the least drunk (having only had a couple of beers) s/he is drowsy, but still offers to drive his/her friends home. Role-play this for 30 seconds.

Getting From Here to There

Ask the students who thinks that this car is less risky, more risky, and just the same as the first car. Be sure to ask questions around any rationalizations of the risks being taken that come up.

- The third car is full of people who have been using marijuana. Assure students that the driver drives high all the time and has never had a problem. Role play this for 30 seconds.

Ask students again if this is less risky, more risky, or just the same as the previous cars. Escalate the stakes of the marijuana car: Ask everyone who was OK with a high driver to sit in the “car.” Change the situation to a high pilot and ask whether they will stay in the plane; those that would not return to the circle.

Continue to escalate for the remaining students: would they allow a high surgeon to operate on them? Would they allow a driver who was high to drive their newborn to an important appointment? Ask the students to explain their rationale.

- The fourth car is full of a young family on the way to hockey practice. All of them are doing everything correctly; seat belts, eyes on the road, not distracting the driver, etc. Ask students to assess the risk to this family given that the other 3 cars are on the road around them.

The fourth car could also be driven by someone impaired on a prescription drug. You should emphasize prescription drugs are medicine. Doctors give them to patients who are sick or injured. If you’re not sick or injured and take a prescription drug it can hurt you. The drug can lead to a dependence or addiction, it can increase your chances of an injury, and in some cases it can kill you. They’re especially harmful when mixed with other drugs, like alcohol. For the driver of a vehicle taking a prescription drug the impact can be unpredictable – the drug could make the driver sleepy or extremely anxious – and so should be avoided.

Discussion

After each scenario, ask the passengers to decide whether they would be comfortable accepting a ride in the car. Students who decide to leave can move back to the circle.

Extensions

- Ask students to identify community resources that chronically impaired drivers can access.
- Discuss potential links between distracted driving and car-pedestrian collisions.

Getting From Here to There

Note

You are not expected to give a detailed explanation of gender identity and/or expression in this class. The goal is to explain the groups will be based on shared experiences. You will have the opportunity to discuss gender in more detail once the groups have been established.

For more information on gender, see the Facilitator's Guide or visit The Youth Project website at www.youthproject.ns.ca.

References

Chamberlain, E., & Soloman, R. (2006, July 7). *Youth and Impaired Driving in Canada: Opportunities for Progress*. Retrieved from MADD Canada website: www.madd.ca/english/research/youth_and_impaired_driving_may_2006.pdf

Splitting into Groups

The following is a guide to explain splitting the class into the groups that will be meeting in the following weeks.

Draw two boxes on the whiteboard labelled “masculine” and “feminine.”

“You might feel like you belong in one of these little boxes, somewhere between them, or outside the board entirely. You’re the expert on your own identity. But the assumptions we make about people in general are usually based on what’s inside these little boxes.”

- Using a different colour marker, draw a handful of arrows coming out of each box.

“You probably know what some of these assumptions are: a baby’s room should be either pink or blue; ‘gifts for him’ are hammers or wallets and ‘gifts for her’ are earrings or necklaces.

“We’re concerned as these assumptions add up, they lead to expectations you might feel pressure to live up to. You probably already know some of these too: some expectations from this box are that you shouldn’t cry, or that you shouldn’t ask for help; some expectations from this box are that you’re too emotional or that you should look good all the time.”

- Ask for more expectations of masculinity and femininity.

“We’re also concerned the pressure to live up to these broad expectations affect the way you think about important issues: things like sex, body image or healthy relationships. We want to make it easier to talk about these issues, so the next time we meet, we’re going to break into two groups: one group will focus on how the expectations of masculinity relate to your health, and the other group will focus on how the expectations of femininity relate to your health. You may not feel all the same pressures in the same way, but we’ve found having groups that share some of these pressures have an easier time talking about them.

“So you have until next week to decide the group that fits you best: masculinity or femininity. If you find out the group you chose isn’t the best fit, you can try the other group.”

Trust and Community Standards

Topic

Communication, safety

Outcomes

No specific outcome for this activity. This session is to lay the foundation of trust and expectations for the group.

Materials

- Soft objects (balls, stuffed animals)
- Flipchart paper
- Markers
- Trust-building activities (see appendix)

Background

- This session will introduce the discussion-style classroom, including check-ins and sitting in a circle. The group will also develop a list of community standards that will help them work best together.
- Have chairs arranged in a circle before the students arrive.

Activity

Explain you'll be starting each session with a check-in question and ending with a check-out question as a way to get to know, and receive feedback from, the students. Remind students that along with the check-in question, you want them to tell the group their preferred name and pronoun. Suggested check-in question: What's something important you want the group to know about you?

Tell the group that this session will be spent getting to know each other and figuring out the best way to work together.

The first activity is "Group Juggle." Ask everyone to stand in a circle with their hands up and palms facing in the circle. Explain that you'll be tossing a ball or soft object through the circle until everyone has a turn. Each person will say the name of the person they're throwing to, and lower their hands after they've caught and thrown the ball. The activity ends when the ball comes back to the facilitator. Ask everyone to remember who they threw the ball to.

Repeat the activity, this time adding in a second ball/object partway through. Repeat again, adding as many objects as you can. Start from the beginning if someone drops or isn't able to catch the ball.

Trust and Community Standards

Extensions

See appendix for other trust-building activities.

Take note of who comes across as a leader or creative thinker.

When finished, ask the group what allowed them to succeed.

Spread out among the room. Ask everyone to think of a favourite place in the world. Then ask the group to think of the floor as a map of the world, and without talking, go to their favourite place on the map. Once everyone has found a place, ask them to say where they are and why it makes sense.

The map won't make sense: Australia might be next to Newfoundland. Ask the group to identify what would have made the process easier. They will likely suggest things like figuring out where North is, or having a reference point.

Bring everyone back into the circle. Explain without a set of standards, it's like using a map without knowing which way is North. Ask the group to come up with standards that will help them work best together. Let them know you might suggest some too. Write down their suggestions on the flip chart paper.

Suggest the following standards if the group doesn't come up with them on their own: confidentiality, being open to try new things, being open to other opinions, protecting the voice of others in the room. Be sure to explain to the group that the facilitator will be held to these standards as well, and ask them to suggest anything a facilitator could do to help with trust or add to these group sessions.

When the group has reached consensus on the standards, let them know you'll be periodically checking in to see how they think the group is living up to the standards.

Check-out: Do you think we can follow the community standards through the semester? (Thumbs up or thumbs down). Revisit the map question and ask the group to explain why they chose the place they did as their favorite place in the world, and if they have been there before.

Expectations of Femininity

Topic

Femininity, help-seeking

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.15 examine the negative impact of stereotyping and stigma upon help-seeking behaviour.

Materials

- An empty backpack
- 15+ cans or other small weights
- Expectations of women printed on separate sheets (see appendix)
- Markers
- Paper

Background

- Clear an area of the room and create a circle of chairs.
- Pile cans/weights on the floor.
- Approach one volunteer to wear the backpack and one to fill it during the activity.

Activity

Check in: What's something about you people would be surprised to find out?

Explain to the class that girls are under pressure to act a certain way to be feminine and "be" a certain way as women. Have a volunteer read each expectation and ask the students if they agree that some girls might feel this. Add a weight to the bag to represent each expectation the group feels. Add multiple cans/weights for those that are validated strongly.

Ask the backpack wearer periodically to do a lap of the circle and if she would mind carrying that weight around all day. At the end of the exercise the backpack should be full.

Let others try the backpack so they can get a feel for how heavy it is.

Arrange the expectation sheets into the shape of a person (head, torso, arms, legs) and ask the students, if they feel comfortable, to walk around and place check marks on the expectations that they feel themselves. Repeat until everyone who would like to participate has had a chance. When the students are finished, take a picture of the "person" to have a record of the pressures this group feels.

Expectations of Femininity

Extensions

- Refer back to “the script” in future activities to reinforce the idea that students may be playing into some of these expectations.

Discussion

- How could these expectations affect our physical health?
- How do these expectations affect our mental health?
- Explain that these expectations act as a script that tells us what to say and how to act. Ask the group what they would think about a person who lives up to all these expectations. Would you want to hang out with her?
- Where do we learn this script? Which of your role models teaches you what it is to be feminine the most?
- How does your surprising detail from the check-in question relate to the script?

Check-out: Imagine you’re going to have a child. If you could get rid of just one of these expectations before your daughter has to deal with it, which would it be?

Angels and Demons

Topic

Safe communities, decision-making

Background

- As a facilitator focus on the power people have in these situations and the choices they make, rather than their role as victims.
- Arrange chairs in a circle

Materials

- Angels & Demons situation (see appendix)
- Chart paper
- Markers

Activity

Check-in: What is one thing you do (or avoid doing) to stay safe? Where do you feel the most safe? Is it a place or a person and why do you think it brings this feeling?

Explain there are a lot of ways we can feel unsafe; both in our close relationships and in the community. No one can fully prevent feeling unsafe, but people have power in how they react to a situation.

Read the class the Angels & Demons scenario, and explain that, while in this case you are in the know about what to expect, in real life you really don't know everything before going into a situation so they should expect the unexpected when thinking the scenario through.

The facilitator can choose, or ask the group, if they would like to divide the class into Angels and Demons or do the activity with the whole class as Angels and then as Demons.

If you're an Angel your mission is to think about what you can do together with the other Angels to make the environment healthier. What will you do to protect the health and safety of your friends? What can you do in advance or dur-

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.1 analyze their health needs in times of change and apply strategies that enhance their capacity to manage change in their lives.
- 9.11 examine the cause and effect of unhealthy relationships and practice communication and assertiveness skills to confront unhealthy relationships.

Note

Consent cannot be obtained after use of force, threats, fear of bodily harm, or by lying.

If you are 12 or 13 years old you can legally have consensual sex with someone who is less than 2 years older than you.

If you are 14 or 15 years old you can legally have consensual sex with someone less than 5 years older than you.

16 is the legal age of consent.

You can't legally consent to have sex with someone who is in a position of authority or trust over you; for example a minister, coach, employer, teacher, or police officer (Dept. of Justice, 2013).

Angels and Demons

Extensions

- Offer the class a Non-violent Crisis Intervention course, or provide information about the course.

ing the party to make it more safe?

If you're a Demon your mission is to make things worse! What will you do at the party that will have a negative impact on the health and safety of your friends?

Give the groups chart paper to record their strategy and inform them that they have some artistic license with the story and its details (e.g. the Angels may bring a box of condoms and the Demons may choose to alter the drinking game and make it happen in the water).

Share and discuss the changes that each side made.

Canvas the group for stories about parties they have been to or heard about and discuss how people acted to make the situation safer or less safe.

Discussion

- Would you want to be at the party?
- Is it possible to party safely anymore?
- If you thought the Demons won, would you want your kids going to the same party in the future?
- Do you think you're going to be a Demon or an Angel this summer? When you hit high school?
- What influences you to behave as an angel or a demon when in a social setting with your friends? With people you don't know? With boys?

Check out: What could you change about your community (school or where you live) to make it more safe for everyone?

Help-seeking Behaviour

Topic

Help-seeking behaviour, stereotypes, mental health, stigma

Materials

- “Help-seeking” signs (see appendix)
- “Who would you ask for help” signs (see appendix)
- “Yes,” “No” and “Maybe” signs (see appendix)

Background

- Place chairs in a circle
- Tape the “yes,” “no” and “maybe” sign on different walls around the room. Display the “Who would you ask for help” signs

Activity

Check-in: Who is one woman (alive, dead or fictional) that you look up to? Explain what it is about this person that you admire.

Present the students with scenarios in which they may ask for help. Ask the students to move to the appropriate sign based on whether they know where to ask for help and would feel comfortable asking for help; are unsure if they would ask for help or unsure where to go; or don’t know where to get help and wouldn’t ask for help.

After each student moves ask girls to explain their choice and encourage sharing of options/ways to help seek. Use the “Who would you ask for help?” signs as suggestions. Discuss the limits to how much each person could help (i.e. could a friend diagnose an STI?).

Some suggested scenarios are you have a sore ankle; you have had a headache for one week; you haven’t felt like getting out of bed; you suspect your friend is in an abusive relationship; you think you may be pregnant; you have strange vaginal discharge.

Go over the help-seeking categories with the group to clarify each one.

Ask student volunteers individually to stand on the sign they feel most girls their age would identify with when they have a problem. Then ask them to

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

9.15 examine the negative impact of stereotyping upon help-seeking behaviour

9.2 recognize the warning signs of depressive disorders and the importance of seeking help for those disorders. (extension topics)

Help-seeking Behaviour

Extensions

- Incorporate an addition to the community resource board in the classroom (see assessment)
- Highlight prominent women who have sought help and been open with their physical and mental health .

move to the sign they feel they'll identify with when they're 20 or 30 and faced with a problem. Finally, ask them to move to where they would want their son or daughter to be, or the option they think is the healthiest. Repeat with several volunteers.

Introduce the idea of "Back-pocket people:" people in your life who you have "in your back pocket," who you can call on in a crisis. Give each student a sheet to write down the names of these people, and encourage them to keep this paper, as it is often difficult to remember these people when a problem arises

Have some students role-play going to a walk-in clinic because they feel they may have an STI. You will need a patient, a receptionist, a doctor and a friend. Use this as a means to discuss how to make asking for help easier. Remind students they don't have to tell a receptionist why they want to see a doctor (they could just say it's "private"). Let them know doctors are trained to help even if you don't know how to talk about the problem.

Extend the conversation to discuss how and where you seek help if you think you may be pregnant, or were sexually assaulted.

Discussion:

- Why did you choose your original help-seeking slide and what factors did you consider when choosing for your older self?
- What are some problems that you can fix yourself? Can you think of any problem that you may not be able to fix (i.e. mental health)? What would you do?
- If you hurt your knee and were having difficulty playing your favourite sport, how long would it take for you to ask for help? What might slow you down or stop you from asking?
- If you felt depressed and didn't feel like playing volleyball anymore, how long would it take you to ask for help? Why is this different from asking for help with physical health problems?
- How can you balance helping your friends with looking after your own needs?
- Do you think guys would answer these questions the same way you did? Why?

References

Hock, Jonathon. (2012, September 5. Hockumentry: Draft Day with Royce White. Retrieved from www.grantland.com/the-triangle/hockumentary-draft-day-with-royce-white.

Check-out: What can you do to make it easier for girls to ask for help?

Drug Land

Topic

Alcohol use, risk-taking behaviour

Materials

- Drinking categories on pieces of paper (see appendix)
- Consequences of alcohol use (see appendix)
- Alcohol and the media sheets (see appendix)

Background

- Clear a space on the floor large enough for the group to stand in a circle.
- Arrange chairs outside this area in a circle.
- Approach a student who may be willing to volunteer first and break the ice when it's time to disclose drinking habits.
- Facilitators are encouraged to participate in this activity.

Activity

Refer to the community standards and remind everyone about the importance of confidentiality and remaining non-judgmental.

Check-in: Why do teenagers drink?

Ask the students to arrange the categories on the floor from Non-drinker to Alcohol Dependent.

Define each category of drinkers with the students. Emphasize both regularity and severity of drinking.

Ask for a volunteer to stand on the category that best represents their own alcohol use. Explain that students can position themselves in-between categories.

Ask others who are comfortable with contributing where they would put themselves on the spectrum.

Ask the students to move to where they think they will be when they are legal drinking age. Repeat for when they go to community college or university, when they enter the workforce and if they start a family. As students move, ask them to explain their rationale.

Explain that the average age Nova Scotians have their first alcoholic drink has dropped from 15 to 13, and that it's becoming more important for younger

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.13 analyze the role of alcohol in the decision making process related to increased risk of unintended pregnancy, STIs, impaired driving, and injury.
- 9.14 practise speaking about concerns regarding substance use and gambling in self or others.

Note

Research shows one in five Nova Scotia drinkers (15 years or older) consume alcohol in a way that damages their health or well-being (N.S. Dept. of Health Promotion and Protection, 2007). The average age of a Nova Scotian taking their first drink is 13 years old (N.S. Dept. of Health and Wellness, 2011).

Drug Land

Extensions

Try to get the group to order the consequence sheets in silence for the first 2 minutes; practising non-verbal communication.

Discuss what to do in case of alcohol poisoning, passing out, or other dangers of alcohol consumption.

Demonstrate the recovery position

References

Changing the Culture of Alcohol Use in Nova Scotia [An Alcohol Strategy to Prevent and Reduce the Burden of Alcohol-Related Harm in Nova Scotia]. (2007). Retrieved from Nova Scotia Department of Health Promotion and Protection website: <http://novascotia.ca/dhw/addictions/documents/Changing-the-Culture-of-Alcohol-Use-in-Nova-Scotia-Strategy.pdf>

Alcohol Indicators Report. (2011). Retrieved from Nova Scotia Government Department of Health of Wellness website: <http://novascotia.ca/dhw/publications/Alcohol-Indicators-Report-2011.pdf>

students to consider the consequences of substance abuse. Be clear that the point of this activity is not to demonize alcohol, but you want students to be as informed as possible.

Ask a volunteer to read the consequences of alcohol use one by one. Quickly explain each as they are laid on the floor and sort them into 2 piles: things that group members have seen happen or heard about and things that don't seem to happen.

Ask the group to order the consequences in the pile that 'happen' from what they perceive to be the least harmful to the most harmful. Students will develop their own rationale for what constitutes "harm." Discuss how often they see these in their community.

Discussion

- Review the order and ask if this is the impression they get from the media. (i.e. do major companies put warnings on beer labels like "May cause sexual assault"? How are women portrayed in beer ads?)
- Are these media related to the drinking or smoking habits of your peers or of even younger students?
- Discuss binge drinking amongst teens and teenage girls in particular and connect this with the script of masculinity/femininity. Explore the idea of drinking to get smashed or to be the most fun person at a party. Discuss the risk of alcohol positioning associated with binge drinking.
- Discuss how the media influences our perception and culture of alcohol, use the 'media and alcohol' sheets to fuel discussion. How does being away of the influence they have change how you see alcohol?

Ask students if they would have been comfortable using to the same activity to discuss marijuana or prescription drugs. Inform the group prescription drugs are medicine. Doctors give them to patients who are sick or injured. If you're not sick or injured and take a prescription drug it can hurt you. A drug can lead to a dependence or addiction, it can make you sick or increase your chances of an injury, and in some cases it can kill you. They're especially harmful when mixed with other drugs, like alcohol. If you're taking them because you're sad or upset there are healthier ways to deal with those feelings.

Check-out: How did this activity make you feel?

Marijuana

Topic

Social pressures, marijuana use, refusal skills

Materials

- Levels of marijuana use (see appendix)
- Pressures to try marijuana (see appendix)
- Blank paper
- Markers

Background

- This activity should be done once a good level of trust has been developed in the group. Be open to discussion and hearing students' ideas.
- Be careful not to reveal the topic of the activity prior to beginning the session.

Activity

Inform the group that you'll be talking about something they're all familiar with. Tell them it's something they hear about in songs, see in movies, and hear about from people at school. It's something they see in the news, and something they can buy supplies for in the store.

Ask the group to guess what you're talking about (they will likely guess sex or alcohol) before revealing you're talking about marijuana. Let them know the goal of the day is to have an honest discussion about marijuana in their lives (experienced or perceived).

Check-in: What are some words/phrases for marijuana or getting high? (Extend by talking about whether these make it seem appealing or not appealing.)

Place the "Levels of use" sheets on the floor and clarify the meaning of each with the group. Begin Step in the Circle, starting asking students to step in the circle based on the level of use, then moving to the pressures of using marijuana that apply to their lives.

Discuss the ways someone could refuse a joint in certain situations (e.g. at a

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.3 recognize the impact that substance use and gambling can have on mental health issues, including depression and anxiety.
- 9.7 synthesize the fundamentals of drug education related to the use of alcohol, tobacco, caffeine, cannabis and other substances, including the short and long term risks and signs of concerns along the continuum of use.
- 9.12 identify and practice negotiation, assertiveness and refusal skills related to sexual activity, tobacco, cannabis and gambling.

Marijuana

Extensions

- Try a “soft-shoe shuffle” during the discussion: ask everyone to stand and as volunteers answer each question, the rest of the class moves closer to person if they agree and farther away if they disagree. Ask for multiple answers for each question to see how the class moves.
- Discuss marijuana use and social capital. Does it give you a way to identify with a certain group?
- Discuss and question assumptions about marijuana: marijuana is non-addictive; healthy and natural; helps your focus.
- Have students create an advertisement to “Sell Marijuana to kids” the way youth are often targeted in advertisements. Use this to discuss potential harms and tactics used by alcohol advertisements.

party with all the same sex, both sexes, older friends, at lunchtime, at a concert). What makes these situations easier/harder to refuse?

Discussion

Ask the group to imagine marijuana was legal. Ask the group to develop the following rules/laws for use. Have one student mediate the discussion.

- What would be the legal age?
- Is driving high allowed? What about ambulance drivers, bus drivers?
- Can your doctor be high?
- Where/how would you get it? Who would decide the cost?
- Could your parents get high?

Be open about the goal for this lesson – you’re not ignoring the realities of experimentation, but you’d like them to think about delaying their first use.

Check-out: Your three year old child can identify the smell of weed. Is this okay? If not, what could change to make sure this isn’t the case?

Relationships

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.22 examine the cause and effect of unhealthy relationships and practice communication and assertiveness to confront unhealthy relationships.

Topic

Friendships, intimate relationships, body image

Materials

- Sheet of scenarios (see appendix)

Background

- It is important for the facilitator to be sensitive to the relationships between students in the group, and consider the relationships they see at home.

Activity

Check-in: Would you date yourself, or be friends with yourself? Why or why not? **NOTE:** Sometimes students may find this question confusing...they may think you're asking them to be a lesbian. You're not, although that can be stated as an option. You're asking the question to have them reflect on their personality and whether or not you'd make a good friend or girlfriend.

Part One

Ask two or three volunteers who are friends to come and stand in the circle about one metre apart so they can see each other. The exercise can be repeated with more than one group.

Ask the girls the following questions:

How did you become friends?
What makes your friendship work?
How does the friendship make you feel?

Now explain that you're going to name some scenarios that might impact the relationship and you'll either move closer to each other, farther away from each other, or stay the same distance apart. Your movement expresses what happens to your relationship as friends. Do you get closer or drift apart a bit? After each statement you can pause and ask for feedback on the movements. Modify the wording if there are three people in the circle. You don't have to use all the scenarios.

Notes

Adolescents may be aware of a growing number of different relationships that impact their daily lives and ones that can influence and impact their health and sense of well-being (family, friends, teachers, partners, etc.). Healthy relationships are an important part of our physical, mental and emotional health. In this lesson students will be given opportunities to think critically about what makes a relationship healthy and what might make a relationship unhealthy.

Relationships

Facilitators can try a couple of rounds with different students, or they can ask the circle to facilitate their own round – choosing two or three new students and asking the girls in the circle to throw out some of the same scenarios, and also some of their own (see appendix for scenarios).

How did this exercise make you feel? Why do you think someone might stay friends with a guy/girl when the relationship doesn't feel right or healthy?

Part Two

Since you have been young you have had many kinds of relationships. The relationship with our families is the first kind that we experience and by the time we entered grade primary, friendships began to take a bigger role in our lives and still do. Now at this stage of your life, you may have or be thinking about another kind of relationship. We sometimes call them romantic relationships or intimate relationships – having a boyfriend or girlfriend. These kinds of relationships can be a rich addition to your life, and can help you be healthier. Sometimes though they can be unhealthy. This part of the lesson is designed to help us understand how to maintain a healthy relationship, and how to recognize when a relationship is becoming unhealthy.

Ask the whole circle to participate in this activity about healthy intimate relationships. Canvas the group for feedback after each question (see appendix for questions).

The questions we just asked help us understand the differences between a healthy and an unhealthy relationship. Stand up and step into the circle if you think you would recognize if you were in an unhealthy relationship. Step into the circle if you think you know how to help build and maintain a healthy relationship. Step into the circle if you think it might take some time before you're ready for a healthy relationship. End this part of the session with the following thought:

What you say and what you do will make people feel something. It might be something good or bad. It might help a relationship or hurt a relationship.

Part Three

Finish off the class, if there's time, with some questions for the group or some additional Step into the Circle statements (see appendix).

Check-out: Complete these sentences.

When I admire a relationship it's because...

When I'm turned off by a relationship it's because...

Extensions

- Extend with similar questions about familial relationships. What makes them different and are they always healthy?
- Examine what your options are if you find yourself in an unhealthy relationship and how you know this. Practice communication strategies and emphasize the importance of addressing these feelings.
- Ask students: What's one thing you would like to change about yourself to make you a better friend or better girlfriend?

Assessment

In a following class ask the students to design a code of conduct or set of rules for friendships and relationships. Three rules for each.

Sexuality Kitchen Sink

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.16 examine issues around hypersexualization of girls and boys and the sexualization of women and men, and how these phenomena can contribute to violence, affect body image and self-esteem and impact relationships.

Healthy Sexuality

Materials

- Prepared slides (see appendix)

Background

- Preceding this session an anonymous question box could be used to gather what students might want to know about.
- Arrange chairs in a circle.
- If a student decides to share personal information remind the class about their community standards around confidentiality and respect; and also remind youth that there are people and resources in the community where students can get more support for an issue related to sex and sexuality.

Activity

Check-in: How and where would you like your kids to learn about sex (examples could include movies, school, parents, friends, etc.)?

Arrange 30 frequently asked questions (FAQs) about sex somewhere in the room with five to 10 markers nearby, or a marker for every student.

Tell the students to quickly move through the FAQs and put a mark on 10 questions they want answered. The facilitator will take the top 10 questions, plus 10 more they believe are important based on their experience and bring them back to the circle.

Take the questions the students picked and answer them first. One suggestion is to pose the question and first ask if the circle has an answer. It may be the correct answer, it may require some additional information, or it may require the facilitator to provide the right answer.

Do the same with the questions identified with the facilitator.

Invite the students to ask new questions, and let them know there will be time during other sessions to answer the remaining questions.

Notes

With puberty comes a range of physical, mental and emotional changes, and many of these changes are associated with sex and sexuality. Many teenagers are curious about sex and sexuality, but seldom have a safe space where questions can be answered.

Sexuality Kitchen Sink

Sample FAQs

- Do all vaginas look alike?**
- What does a clitoris do?**
- Do other parts of the body become aroused?**
- What's the average size for a penis?**
- Do all penises look alike?**
- How much masturbation is normal?**
- What's in semen and where does it come from?**
- Can sexual intercourse hurt?**
- Is pulling out of the vagina or anus and ejaculating a safe form of birth control or safer sex?**
- What is pre cum?**
- If you masturbate too much will you run out of sperm?**
- If I'm attracted to someone of the same gender does it mean I'm gay or bi?**
- What's an orgasm?**
- Is a male orgasm different from a female orgasm?**
- Can alcohol and other drugs, and tobacco impact your sexual health?**
- Do females masturbate?**
- Should I shave my pubic hair?**
- What does circumcision mean and does it impact our health?**
- What's a wet dream?**
- What are blue balls?**
- What if I'm having trouble getting an erection and ejaculating?**
- How many erections each day are normal?**
- When does puberty start and stop?**
- How much cum is normal?**
- What is birth control?**
- What does horny mean and what's normal?**
- What's lube all about?**
- What are periods and are they gross?**

Closing:

The more youth know about their body, the better they are to help keep it healthy. Encourage youth to ask questions about sex.

Check-out: What's one memorable (useful?) fact you took away today?

Extensions

Ask at the end of the session which unanswered questions seem the most important now. Follow up with these in the next session or get volunteers to research them and bring back the answers next time.

Shrinking Women

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

9.15 examine the negative impact of stereotyping upon help-seeking behaviour

Topic

Feminine stereotypes, expectations of men

Materials

- One copy of *Shrinking Women* by Lily Myers for every student (see appendix)
- List of Expectations of Men (see appendix)
- Up to 20 blank pieces of paper
- Markers
- Computer
- Projector

Background

- Have a projector in the room set up to play the YouTube video of *Shrinking Women* (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zQucWXWp3k>).

Activity

Check-in: Two truths and a lie. Each student shares details about them: two are true and one is a lie. The rest of the group votes which detail is the lie.

Explain to the group you'll be reading a poem about the pressures of femininity. Show the video. After watching the performance, hand out one copy of the poem to each person.

Ask each group member to select a line that stood out for her and explain her reasoning. Encourage the group to relate their answers to "the script" from the Expectations of Women activity.

Explain they are not alone in feeling societal pressures, and that masculinity has its own backpack full of expectations. Ask the group to try to identify the expectations of masculinity and write each one on a piece of paper.

Compare the list you've created to the list of pressures from the Expectation of

Shrinking Women

Masculinity activity. Discuss any differences in the two lists.

Ask the group to identify influences in a boy's life that may amplify these pressures.

Discussion

- How are the expectations of masculinity and the expectations of femininity related?
- How do these expectations make your life harder? How do they make your life easier?
- What do you want the other group to know about the expectations you feel pressure to live up to?
- What do you think the other group wants you to know about their pressures?
- When did these expectations start to play a role in your lives?

Check-out: What happens to boys who feel pressured to live up to their expectations?

Extensions

Have the group present the list of expectations to the other group. Allow time for questions about any differences in the generated list and the "official" list.

Have students write their own poems about the expectations they face.

References

Lily Myers - "Shrinking Women" (CUPSI 2013). (2013, April 13). Retrieved August 15, 2014.

Online and Offline

Topic

Social Media, relationships

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

9.16 examine issues around hypersexualization of girls and boys and the sexualization of women and men, and how these phenomena can contribute to violence, affect body image and self-esteem and impact relationships .

Materials

- Pages with examples of social media activity (see appendix)

Background

- Consider mixing the two groups for this activity.
- Prepare a list of social media blunders you can use in your fake interviews. For example, “I saw a picture on Instagram of you throwing up in someone’s flower pot,” “Your Twitter account seems to be mostly concerned with rating porn videos,” “Your Facebook statuses are always complaining about school. How will I know you won’t complain to your friends about work?”
- Arrange chairs in a circle

Activity

Check-in: What would be your ideal summer job and what would be your ideal career?

Tell the group you’ll be role-playing job interviews so they can have a taste of what to expect when they begin to look for summer jobs.

Choose a student to participate in a mock job interview. Start with general questions such as asking for their greatest strengths or weaknesses.

When the student feels comfortable, ask a question about their social media activity: “What would I learn about you from looking at your social media accounts?”

Start asking more specific questions: “You said _____ about your teacher on Twitter. What can I expect from you as an employee?” “You’ve changed your Facebook profile picture 10 times in two weeks; what’s your time management strategy?” etc.

Repeat if you have other volunteers. Inform the group that potential employers

Online and Offline

Extensions

- Have students identify ads they see on social media that seem to be targeted to their interests. Discuss the implications of having information online.

will sometimes search for people on various social media sites.

Reveal to students you're actually focusing on how their online lives interact with their real-world lives.

Start a round of Step in the Circle. Here are some suggested statements:

- I pay attention to the number of Twitter followers I have.
- I've friended someone I don't know.
- I have more than two social media accounts.
- I've said something online/texted that I wouldn't say face-to-face.
- I think about who's reading my Facebook statuses.

Spread the social media activity pages (see appendix) on the floor and ask the group to arrange them into two piles: "OK" and "Not OK."

Ask the group to explain their rationale for each choice and to describe whether they'd changed their minds on any of the examples. For example, the students might only put sheets in the "Not OK" pile if they violate laws such as child porn or cyber-bullying. Discuss whether the law is only factor in deciding their actions in real life.

Bring up the idea of online safety. What are some consequences of making your phone number public? How much do you reveal about yourself if you're talking to someone online for the first time?

Go back to the job interview. Identify that people in interviews try to project the best image, regardless of whether it's the "real you." Discuss whether a social media profile is a more accurate representation of someone's personality. Suggest that an online persona is also a form of performance. Where is the "real you?" What factors influence these performances?

Check-out: What's something you regret putting online?

Privilege

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.22 examine how design and infrastructure of the school community and surrounding community enhances or creates barriers for physical activity among youth
- 9.23 investigate principles of and beliefs around financial health and demonstrate an awareness of the capacity for financial health to positively or negatively affect ones' state of health

Topic

Privilege, social determinants of health

Materials

- Printed ducks and towns (see appendix)
- Social determinants of health on sheets (see appendix)
- 'The Line' questions (see appendix)

Background

- Arrange chairs in a circle
- Depending on the group, it may be necessary to express the importance of maintaining a safe space during this discussion as students will share personal information.

Activity

Check in: What is something about you that you think makes you different from everyone else in the room? Try to go deeper than name. If students do share a difference that turns out to be the same as someone else in the group

Introduce the 10 ducks. Explain that all of these ducks were born basically identical in the same duck hospital, the only difference being that they were born in two different ponds. Allow the students to name these two ponds.

Explain that Pond 1 ducks live to be 12 years old—really old for a duck—and Pond 2 ducks live to be 7. Ask students what might be going on in each pond.

Ask the group to identify some things affecting the life span and health of the ducks in these two ponds. As they identify them drop the social determinant of health that this relates to on the floor until each has been mentioned. Stop periodically to question students (e.g. "But how does education affect your life span?").

After students have identified all of the social determinants that they can with the ducks flip the paper over to reveal the town. Ask students to identify the remaining social determinants by thinking in terms of people and their communities.

Note

This session is best done in a multi-gender group to help showcase the difference in privilege between gender groups.

Privilege

Explain that these factors are the social determinants of health, and that this means your health is influenced by your place in society. Explain that these factors don't predict the future but they create barriers for some people that don't exist for others; making it harder for them. Important is the message that **any** duck can rise out of any pond to succeed.

Ask for volunteers to talk about how they fare personally as a particular social determinant is concerned (i.e. "How is your access to education?").

Ask students to stand up and push back all of the chairs to the wall. Students should line up across the middle of the room leaving a few feet in front and behind themselves (not facing each other).

Use the list of questions to instruct students to either step forward or back. This should be done in silence.

When all of the questions have been asked prompt students to look around and see the variation in the room and then return to the circle.

Solicit volunteers who ended up at different places in the room and ask them how the activity felt and why they think they ended up where they did. Introduce the word 'privilege' for what was just measured in that activity. It is important to reinforce that privilege is not destiny but certainly can make things harder for some people than other. It is also important to point out that everyone is privileged in some ways and not in others but that people need to be conscious of how their privilege manifests itself.

Ask students to go around the circle and name one way that they are privileged and one way they are not; based on those questions or not.

Discussion

- Should you feel guilty for your privilege? Do you?
- What can you do if you are very privileged to make things better for others?

Remind students of the positive effects of an activity like this; especially of finding out our similarities with others.

Check out: How did this session feel to you?

Extensions

- You can replace either the ducks activity or The Line with a role-playing activity on privilege (see appendix)
- Begin the 'Design your own neighbourhood' project referenced in the assessment materials
- Play the board game "The Last Straw" as a group.
- Show a video of "The Line" taking place with another group ("What is Privilege?" by BuzzFeed Yellow on YouTube, for example).

Note

The line activity could be done with eyes closed or open. The group may have a preference but facilitators should be aware to watch out for situations that might make students feel unsafe or singled out.

Popularity

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.11 examine the cause and effects of unhealthy relationships and practice communication and assertiveness skills to confront unhealthy relationships.

Topic

Social pressures, femininity expectations, empathy, bullying

Materials

- Scenario cards (see appendix)
- Chart paper/board
- Hurtful vocabulary list (see appendix)

Background

- Arrange chairs in a circle.
- The facilitator should be sensitive to any social stratification that may exist in the group and speak in the hypothetical. Refer to the “ideal girl” as the popular girl and reminding the group that no one fits her mold.

Activity

Check-in: What would make your 15-year-old daughter the most popular girl in school? Record the answers for all girls to consider.

Ask the group if they think there is anything we are missing from this list of what makes someone popular.

Now explain to the group that you’ll pretend that “the ideal girl” is the most popular girl in high school. Place a stack of potential scenarios face down on the floor and ask girls to draw one card, read it aloud and as a group decide if this scenario would affect her popularity. They can sort the cards into “yes” or “no” piles based on consensus.

Consider the piles as a group once all the cards have been sorted. It’s likely many of the factors that determine popularity are superficial and ignore the type of person the ideal girl is.

Mid-point check-in: What is the ideal girl’s personality like? Is she mean?

Discuss why we associate certain personality qualities with

Popularity

this girl. Do we assume she'll be a bully? Why?

Ask for a volunteer to role-play being a bully. The facilitator should sit very close to this person and ask to be bullied for one minute (verbally, or have the volunteer describe how she would do it physically). Next, the facilitator should to be bullied behind her back and leave the room for five minutes.

Return to the group and ask them to share what they did. Are both of these examples bullying? Which would they be more likely to see in a group of girls? Talk about how bullying can be physical, but often it is insidious, hurtful and difficult to see. Ask the girls to think about other examples of the type of bullying that they see.

Ask the group to think about who is often being bullied, and make a connection between this person and the expectations of women. These girls are likely those who least live up to these expectations, but we know that no one can live up to all of these expectations, so why do we bully?

Explain to the group that bullying can happen in ways they may not notice. There is a strong vocabulary that can be used to keep girls down and contributes to the expectations of women.

Ask for two volunteers to role-play as a girl and a guy. Give the remaining members of the group sticky notes with a word from the hurtful vocabulary list and ask them to stick the note on the person who they think of when they hear this phrase.

Discuss the differences and reason for these common yet hurtful words.

Check-out: What's a characteristic you want to be known for?

Extensions

- Have volunteers from the group run a similar activity with Grade 7 girls.

Myself and My Shell

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.16 examine issues around hyper-sexualisation of girls and boys and the sexualisation of women and men, and how these phenomena can contribute to violence, affect body image and self-esteem and impact relationships.

Topic

Self image, self-appreciation, societal expectations

Background

- This activity could follow the discussions on body image and pornography. The aim is for the girls to take some of the societal messages that we discussed during these activities and consider how they fit in with these ideas.
- Arrange chairs in a circle with space in the centre

Materials

- Description words (see appendix)
- Pictures from magazines (random, at least 25 pictures)
- Paper (1 for each student, folded into a fan)
- Markers
- Sticky notes
- Old magazines
- Paper bags (2 per student)

Activity

Part 1

Check-in: Two truths and a lie. Each student must tell two truths and one lie about themselves, and the rest of the group will guess which is the lie.

Spread the descriptor words in the middle of the circle and ask the students to write down two words that describe them. Ask each girl to share the words they picked.

Discuss their choices. Were they easy to make? What made them choose some words and keep others on the floor? Most girls will pick “safe” words, and leave the more celebratory words on the floor. Discuss why it is so difficult to say things that boost or acknowledge our confidence, or move beyond physical features.

Try the activity again, and challenge the girls to pick up the words that really describe them, not what they think they should say.

Myself and My Shell

Part 2

Begin by talking about girls and compliments; how great it is that girls are often quick to compliment others. Ask the students to describe what makes them want to compliment others. What are they usually complimenting (clothing, hair, body shape)? Ask students why this is, and how this feels.

Challenge students to think about ways you can compliment others that go a little deeper. Create a list of things you can compliment that aren't physical traits. Provide each student with a folded fan and ask them to write their names on the first fold. Students pass the fans around and add a compliment or message to their peers that go beyond the superficial. Every student adds to one fold of the fan, so comments remain anonymous. Collect the fans and compile lists for each student to see in the next class.

Part 3 (suggested second hour)

Check-in: Spread magazine pictures on the floor and have each girl pick out the image that stands out to them. Go around the circle and have the students share their image and the reason they selected it. Talk about the content of the image and the meaning and depth that each person brings to it.

Pass out the words from the previous activity. Ask the students if it was easier to say these things to others than say them about yourself. Why? Is it okay to like yourself?

Introduce the idea of Myself—your true self— and My Shell—what you represent to others.

Give each student two bags; one to represent their self and one to represent their shell. Lay out several magazines and blank paper and ask the students to find or make words or images that represent their self and their shell. This is a silent activity, but encourage students to find images for each other.

Once completed ask any girl who is comfortable to share their two bags and talk about the differences. As a group discuss why they feel they need to create a shell and what made them sort things into the inner self or outer shell pile.

Check-out: What would happen if your self and your shell piles were the same?

Extensions

- Extend the shell vs. self activity to have the girls create collages or masks from the images they cut out.
- Discuss why it's not okay for a girl to have certain traits (funny, sarcastic), or why certain words that are strictly reserved for girls (bossy, opinionated, strong, etc.)
- Give each student a piece of paper to write a "rant" on. They can write whatever they are feeling after this class. Offer to let them keep it or shred it at the end of the period.

Who do I want to be?

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

9.15 examine the negative impact of stereotyping upon help-seeking behaviour.

9.16 examine issues around hypersexualization of girls and boys and the sexualization of women and men, and how these phenomena can contribute to violence, affect body image and self-esteem and impact relationships

Topic

Body image, pornography

Materials

- Ideal woman attributes printed 1 page each
- Markers
- Women's and men's fitness/fashion magazines

Background

The body image activity may not take an entire class. The group can move into a discussion on pornography which will set up the following week's activity on healthy relationships.

Activity

Check-in: What's your self-esteem on a scale from 1 to 10? Answers can include a range of numbers (e.g. "5 to 8"). Before students answer, you may have to define self-esteem.

Split the students into two groups. One will draw the "ultimate man" and the other will describe the "ultimate woman." Tell the groups the "ultimate woman" would live up to all the expectations of femininity and the "ultimate man" would live up to all the expectations of masculinity.

Provide the following prompts make this as detailed as possible:

- How tall is s/he?
- How much does s/he weigh?
- What's his/her body type?
- Does s/he have piercings or tattoos?
- What type of clothes does s/he wear?
- Describe his/her hairstyle and body hair.
- Describe his/her face.

Ask each group to present their drawings to the other group. Pull out the magazine pictures and point out the similarities between the groups' drawings and these depictions.

Who do I want to be?

Direct the discussion toward connecting these “ultimate” people to more realistic and healthier expectations. You can use the following questions:

- Do these people exist? Are they realistic?
- Are they healthy? (*physically, mentally, emotionally*)
- What are their personalities like?
- Where do these ideals come from? If you are following stereotypes, what influences these stereotypes?
- How do these ideals affect your health?
- Would you want to be her?
- If you were a mother, would you want your 15-year-old daughter or son to be her or him?
- How can we help people feel good about their bodies?
- How does your cultural background affect the expectations you feel pressure to live up to?

Split the group evenly into two teams. Inform them they will be debating whether regularly viewing pornography is a healthy activity. You can decide whether to follow traditional debate rules (opening remarks, rebuttals) or to allow a more freeform discussion. As a facilitator, you should use this as an opportunity to see what health factors (relationships, moderation, etc.) the boys use when considering pornography.

When each side has had a chance to make its case, ask the students to identify the side they would have chosen. Ask for volunteers to explain if their mind was changed during the debate.

Check-out: Would you date yourself?

Extensions

- Ask students to find examples of these ideals in advertisements and other media. They can share the most egregious examples of stereotyping and suggest the rationale for such decisions.
- Discuss how race plays a role in the ideals boys and girls feel pressure to live up to. Would the ideal man look different if he was black, for example?

STIs

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.6 identify ways of maintaining sexual health.
- 9.10 apply communication and interpersonal skills to discuss reproductive and sexual health issues.

Topic

Sexual health, STIs, help-seeking

Materials

- Sheet for each STI to be discussed (see appendix)
- STI trivia questions (see appendix)
- Excuses and Responses sheet (see appendix)
- List of consequences of contracting an STI (see appendix)

Background

- Set up chairs in a large circle with room in the middle for the group to stand up and walk around.
- Familiarize yourself with the STI information before the class begins.

Activity

Check in: Describe a time you waited to see if a problem would get better on its own.

Begin with everyone standing inside the circle. Students role-play being at a party. They need to fist-bump with three people, remembering who they were and the order (“you’ll never forget your first!”). They may want to write these down on a small piece of paper. Note that in a smaller class, fewer bumps per student will work better,

Explain that this is a group of students who party together. Choose one student and explain that they’ve had an STI since before the party began (you could describe the nature of the STI). Ask any students who “bumped” with Patient Zero to stand, and inform them that they now have an STI. Explain they’re responsible to get tested and inform previous partners. Repeat the process with students who “bumped” with any of these students in the second and third round. After three rounds, a maximum of eight people could be infected.

Ask students the following questions: what did you notice about the spread of the STI? What would you want to do or know to prevent an STI? Does this

STIs

spread only happen with intercourse? What are the types of STIs?

Spread the names of STIs on the floor ask students if they know anything about them. Begin the STI trivia activity. Students should be in small teams with a whiteboard. Students will answer questions related to transmission, treatment, symptoms and prevention (see appendix).

Ask a volunteer to describe an STI test. Share that testing can happen regularly and STIs can be detected with a blood and urine test, without a physical exam. Stress that students don't need to be experts on symptoms, but you want them to know about prevention, testing and treatment of STIs.

Pair students up and give each group two or three possible excuses. Give the students a few minutes to look at their excuses practice potential responses with their partners. It will be important to establish the context that they are going to enter into a sexual relationship with someone they care about. Encourage them to practice what they would say in the moment rather than relying on slogans such as "no glove, no love." Come back to the larger group and ask pairs to share the excuse and responses they came up with asking for additional thoughts from the larger group. The appendix includes a list of potential responses you can discuss if students are hesitant to share.

Probe them to discuss whose responsibility it is to bring protection and talk about protection. Extend this to role-play, telling your current and previous partners that you have an STI. Swap volunteers if others want to try.

Discussion

- If you thought you'd contracted an STI, who might you tell first? Where would you feel comfortable going for treatment.
- Try to dispel myths about testing. A painful swab isn't needed, just a blood or urine test that can be done regularly if requested.
- Whose responsibility is it to bring protection or to bring it up?
- How do the expectations of men/women from the backpack activity relate to risks of contracting STIs?
- If some are easily treatable why do we need to prevent them? List the consequences (resistance to treatment, mutation in the virus, risk of pregnancy or sterility, personal morals, etc.)

Check-out: What would make it easier to get an STI test?

Extensions

- Ask students to role-play disclosing their STI status to an ex.
- Discuss whether everyone should receive the HPV vaccine.
- Discuss whether condoms and other preventative measures should be free.
- Discuss some of the choices they see other youth make which would increase risk of STIs (no condom use, multiple partners, etc.)

The Sex Game

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.6 identify ways of maintaining sexual health.
- 9.10 apply communication and interpersonal skills to discuss reproductive and sexual health issues.

Topic

Sexual health, birth control, pregnancy

Background

- This activity is purposefully fun to break down some of the taboos and seriousness of sexual health. The facilitator should encourage students to ask any questions they may have on the topic.
- It may be useful to allow students to know the topic prior to the lesson, or set up an anonymous question box in the classroom.
- Arrange chairs in a circle.

Materials

- Condoms (one per student)
- Props for condom-use practice—bananas or similar
- Scrap paper or small white boards
- Sexual health scenarios (see appendix)
- Condom play activities (see appendix)
- Fact or fiction scenarios (see appendix)

Activity

Check-in: Have you ever watched a movie/TV show that was rated R or for adults only? What is your first memory of this?

Split the students into small teams, so that you have at least three groups in the class. Explain that you'll be discussing sex and sexual health through small activities. You can choose to keep score, name the teams, and award a winner at the end.

Round 1

Give each group a whiteboard or pile of scrap paper.

Give each group one of the scenarios and a set amount of time to come up with as many options or "things to be thinking about" as possible. Explain that one point will be awarded for each acceptable answer, so they should get as

The Sex Game

many as possible.

When time is up ask each group to read out the scenario and list their answers. Solicit any additional answers from other groups afterward and ask if there are any questions that the groups would like answered.

Round 2

Complete the condom play activities.

Round 3

Read aloud the “Fact or Fiction” statements and instruct each team to decide if the statement is true (fact) or false (fiction).

Each team should write FACT or FICTION on either side of a piece of paper and all teams wait to reveal their choice at the same time. Discuss the statement and address any questions students may have. A point should be awarded for each correct answer.

Check-out: At what age do you think people are ready to make an informed decision about having sex? At what age would your son be allowed to have sex? Your daughter?

Extensions

- Award a point for every instance in this session that someone can point out a heteronormative or homophobic comment/assumption.
- In Round 1, you could give each group a different scenario rather than comparing what each group came up with for the same scenarios.
- Invite the Youth Health Centre to speak with the class about the services they provide at the junior high or high school.

Mood

Topic

Detection, coping strategies, help-seeking , empathy

Materials

- Signs and symptoms sheets (see appendix)
- Deep breathing and other coping strategies descriptions (see appendix)

Background

- Discussions about mental health should be incorporated into the check-ins throughout the semester to normalize speaking about feelings and thoughts.
- Discussions about suicide should take place only in the context of depression. Students should not go away feeling responsible for friends' suicidal feelings, but should be encouraged to seek adult help if such a situation occurs.
- Arrange chairs in a circle.

Activity

Check-in: What's one thing that always seems to worry you?

Describe "mood" as the way a person feels at a particular time (generally whether someone is feeling good or bad). Mood is sometimes caused by an event, but other times it may not be related to anything specific.

Discuss the effect the length of time a person is worried affects the severity of the issue:

- You're worried about a test or a game for one day
- You're worried for a week
- You're worried for a month

Students should be beginning to differentiate between normal feelings and mental health issues. Explain that everyone experiences stresses, worries, and ups and downs in mood. Share that stress or worry becomes more of an issue when it interferes with normal functioning, as with depression (consistently low mood, sadness) and anxiety (frequent fear or worry).

Ask for a volunteer to move to the middle of the circle and show what anxiety

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.1 analyze their health needs in times of change and apply strategies that enhance their capacity to manage change in their lives.
- 9.2 recognize the warning signs of depressive disorders and the importance of seeking help for those disorders.

Mood

Extensions

- Formal techniques for managing anxious or depressive feelings should extend, not replace, students' own coping strategies, and are best integrated when acquired over time. Introduce extensions as warm-up or warm-down activities in other lessons as time permits (see Appendix).
- Ask students to keep a journal to record when they feel worried. They can keep track of what upset them and how they dealt with it. If students are comfortable, they can later share their successes or challenges.

looks like and what depression looks like. Ask for another volunteer to demonstrate. As a facilitator, move to the middle and act normal. Ask the group if someone can act normal and still have these feelings.

Share that depression and anxiety are not just experienced in the brain, but have a number of physical signs (something you can see from the outside) and symptoms (something you feel on the inside).

Present the students with the signs and symptoms sheets in no particular order. Ask them to quickly sort the sheets into “signs” and “symptoms.”

Discussion

- How much of what a person is experiencing when anxious or depressed can be seen from the outside?
- What can we do to know how the person really feels (emphasize the importance of deeper communication)?
- How can we support a friend who may be having some of these feelings (emphasize offering support, listening without judgement, validating feelings, and seeking additional help)

Explain that we all have ways of dealing with depressed and anxious feelings: some in the moment and some more long-term. Ask students to share something they do when they're feeling down or anxious. Discuss possible reasons for their behaviours and whether they're helpful. Explain that you can think of these behaviours as messages from the body, like a sore muscle after you exercise.

Share with the group that there are also formal techniques that people can use to reduce anxious feelings or low mood. Introduce the deep breathing exercise.

Check-out: How did the deep breathing exercise feel and how do you feel now?

Mindfulness

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.1 analyze their health needs in times of change and apply strategies that enhance their capacity to manage change in their lives

Topic

Mindfulness, mental health, automatic reactions, coping

Materials

- Raisin exercise (see Appendix)
- Raisins
- Seven attitudes of mindfulness (see Appendix)
- Sitting meditation script (see Appendix)

Background

- The purpose of mindfulness is to experience the present moment without judging it as good or bad, and to become aware of automatic thoughts and feelings.
- Some students may find that paying attention to their thoughts and feelings can be upsetting or causes some anxiety. Students should feel free to opt out of exercises they find uncomfortable.

Activity

Check in: What's something that frustrates you a lot, and how do you usually react?

Explain to the group that when we're frustrated, upset, or stressed, it's like there's a mental tornado in our minds—thoughts and feelings are whirling around in our heads, but it's hard to focus on any one of them.

Explain that, when people are stressed or frustrated, they may react automatically to situations without thinking about what they are saying or doing. By intentionally paying attention to thoughts and feelings, students can learn to respond in more helpful ways.

Share the definition of mindfulness: Mindfulness means paying attention in a particular way: On purpose, in the present moment, and nonjudgmentally. Explain that mindfulness is a form of meditation that has been used to help people cope with stress, anxiety, depression, and illness.

Let the group know that mindfulness is not something you can do wrong, and is not about getting rid of difficult feelings or thoughts; it's about being present with them.

Mindfulness

Introduce the raisin exercise. Each student is given one raisin and instructed not to eat it until prompted. Explain the goal is to pay closer attention to sensations and experiences as they're happening. Encourage students to participate without judging their experiences as good or bad.

Discussion

- What did you notice from the experience of eating this way?
- Ask the group what it would be like to do other activities mindfully (examples: Walking to school, brushing teeth, doing chores, etc.)

Share that paying attention in this way can have a calming effect for some people. Explain that mindfulness offers the greatest benefit when it's done regularly as a practice. If students struggle with fluctuations in mood, mindfulness can remedy some of those feelings. Mindfulness can be thought of as a preventative strategy for stabilizing mood, rather than a quick fix during periods of crisis or acute stress.

Explain the seven attitudes of mindfulness as an introduction to the guided sitting meditation.

Encourage students to share any thoughts about the exercise, how it felt, or how they are feeling after doing it. Ask the group if they noticed any challenges in doing meditation.

Check-out: What's one thing, big or small, that you're feeling grateful for today?

Note

Mindfulness is derived from Eastern meditative practices and has a history that extends beyond applications in mental health. Affixing goals to the practice of mindfulness (examples: to become more relaxed, work through difficult feelings, experience greater empathy, etc.), in some ways, goes against its philosophical core of being non-directive and non-striving. Students and facilitators should be aware that, while there are documented benefits to mindfulness, they should not be promoted as the goals of practice itself.

Extensions

Gratitude exercise: Ask students if they've ever had a negative experience they were later able to find some good in. Ask the group things they can say to themselves to look at situations differently.

References

Kabat-Zinn, J. 1990. *Full catastrophe living: the program of the Stress Reduction Clinic at the University of Massachusetts Medical Center*, New York: Dell Publishing.

Kabat-Zinn, J., Massion, A. O., Kristeller, J., Peterson, L. G., Fletcher, K. E., & Pbert, L. (1992). Effectiveness of a meditation-based stress reduction program in the treatment of anxiety disorders. *American Journal of Psychiatry*, 149, 936–943.

Super Powers

Outcomes

Students will be expected to:

- 9.1 analyze their health needs in times of change and apply strategies that enhance their capacity to manage change in their lives.

Topic

Life skills, resilience, seeking help.

Materials

- Pieces of paper with “villains” on them (see appendix)
- Pieces of paper with “super powers” on them (see appendix)

Background

- Arrange chairs in a circle.
- Explain the activity to one student prior to the activity and ask him/her to volunteer first.
- Place “villains” in a large circle and “super powers” in a larger circle around it.

Activity

Check in: If you could have one super power, what would it be?

Explain that we’re worried students moving into high school could succumb to certain pressures (villains), but that they may have some protective strategies (super powers) to help them fight back.

Ask a student to describe each of the villains.

Explain that prescription drugs are medicine that doctors give them to patients who are sick or injured. If you’re not sick or injured and take a prescription drug it can hurt you. A drug can lead to a dependence or addiction, it can make you sick or increase your chances of an injury, and in some cases it can kill you. They’re especially harmful when mixed with other drugs, like alcohol. If you’re taking them because you’re sad or upset there are healthier ways to deal with those feelings.

Ask for a volunteer to walk two laps inside the circle; one to list the villains they think they’ll face and the next to list the super powers they have already or will need to develop to help.

Super Powers

Repeat using a new volunteer until several people have had a turn.

Discussion

- Which super villain is the toughest and which super power is the most important?
- What can you do to build some of these super powers if you don't have them already?
- Are there any other super powers or super villains that belong in this list?
- What can prevent someone from using a super power?
- How can you make sure you know your super powers and the appropriate time to use them?

Check out: Imagine yourself in 10 years. What super power would you want to make sure you had?

Extensions

- Ask students to write scenarios using the super powers and villains. e.g. "A boy was abusing alcohol but was able to ask for help and overcome it because he had close ties to his family." Encourage them to be creative.
- Have students who didn't volunteer write their superpowers from the activity and how these will be protective for them.

The Girlympics

Topic

Stereotypes of femininity

Outcomes

No outcomes are fully covered in this activity. Instead it serves to further confront stereotypes of masculinity and finish off the group in a fun and memorable way.

Materials

- Paper and pens/pencils for every student
- Tape
- A different coloured pen/marker for each student
- Prizes
- Advertisements depicting women as sexualized and objectified.
- Digital camera/students phones
- Numbers 1-50 on single pieces of paper (extension)

Background

- Arrange chairs into a circle.
- Have desks or surfaces available elsewhere for all group members to write on.

Activity

Begin by explaining that the Girlympics is a set of competitions that girls around the world should be striving to excel in and that it is considered very prestigious to win a gold in any one of them.

The Girlympics consists of up to 6 events and everyone who wants to can compete in each one.

- **Ugly Selfie Contest:** Challenge students to take the “ugliest” selfie to be shared with the group. The facilitator will determine the winner but bonus points will be awarded to students who post their image to social media.
- **Re-design an advertisement:** Present students with an advertisement depicting females in a negative light. Challenge them to redesign the advertisement with the same components and product, but a different message.

The Girlympics

Extensions

- Have group members suggest other events for the Girlympics, or events that this group's male equivalent could do in the Brolympics.
- Check out the #banbossy campaign online and show the promotional video when holding the comeback competition.
- Challenge the group to complete a group task requiring planning and communication. Give each girl sheets with a number from 1-50. Give them three tries and freedom in strategy to place all numbers on the floor in numerical order. Time each trial and allow two minutes in between for strategizing.
- **Comeback competition:** Present students with a stereotypical put-down. This may be obvious, like "Bitch" or "on your period" or less blatant like "bossy" or "pushy." Challenge each student or team, to come up with the best comeback to be dramatically performed to the group. Select a winner based on the comeback, as well as the performance.
- **Vagina Campaign:** This activity could take different forms, but the aim is to challenge students to be comfortable talking about the female body. You may want to ask the girls to write and present a speech encouraging people to "Vote Vagina" - talking about all the features, high-points and bonuses of having female anatomy. You may also want to have students start to tell a story, and present them with words on cue-cards that they have to incorporate into the story (ex. vagina, vulva, ovaries, clitoris, mons pubis). Points could be awarded for creativity, saying the words without laughing.
- **Best complimenter:** Each student is given a marker/pen of a different colour and has a piece of paper taped to their back. The group spends several minutes writing compliments on the back of others until each member has written one for all others. Spend a few minutes to decide on which compliment is the best, taking into consideration the depth of the compliment (e.g. "You make me feel at ease" being deeper than "I like your hair.") and report this to the facilitator. The students who are chosen the most win! They can take these sheets home to keep after the event.
- **Self-assertion:** The aim here is for the students to assert their ideas, even when they seem to be going against the group or the norm. This could be done in different ways, however you may want to have a facilitator share a "personal story" seeking advice from the group (ex. you or a friend is in a relationship with someone who is limiting what they can do on their spare time). Look for reassurance from the group that this is okay, and that "waiting it out" is best. The girls earn points for going against the facilitator and sharing what they should do. Alternatively, present the girls with 10+ images of women. Ask the girls to write down which of these women is the most a.) happy, b.) successful and c.) caring. Prompt them to explain their rationale, and provide point to the students who do not answer the question because they do not know these women and can only judge their appearance.

Closing

Notes

Effort should be made to acknowledge students are leaving this group as different people compared to when they came in, having experienced a rite of passage of sorts.

Note: It is recommended that the group end with a full session to close, after all other activities are finished.

Materials

- Cans/weights and backpack from “Expectations of Femininity” activity; one weight for each person participating
- A blank piece of paper and marker for each student

Activity

Check in: What’s one memory you have and one lesson you value from this group?

Place the backpack, full of the cans, in the centre of the circle and ask students to guess what it is that is contained in there. Answer “no” until they are listing the expectations of femininity from the earlier activity. Ask them to close their eyes and spend two minutes to silently think about how these expectations affect them.

Distribute the pieces of paper and markers, asking students to write a positive expectation or something they want to be like on the page; knowing that they do not need to share these.

Explain that the next part of this session will be a ceremony to show that the students are starting to shed these expectations and take control of their own lives.

Students should line up along a wall and the student at one end should start to unpack the backpack, passing the cans/weights down the line. When everyone has one explain that now the expectations are being held by everyone; each person taking part of the load.

After standing and considering this in silence for a short time each student should get their paper in one hand and can/weight in the other to come forward, in order, from one end to the other to place their can next to the backpack. On the way back to the line they should place their paper in the backpack.

Explain that the traditional expectations are being rejected and new ones are being chosen.

Students should line up all facing the same direction quietly.

Closing

Explain that students should wear the backpack long enough to notice the importance of the weight difference, then pass it slowly along to the next person in line by putting it on them.

A facilitator should start, modelling the reflective time with the backpack on and then placing the backpack on the person in front of them. The last one should go back to a facilitator who then places the backpack in the centre of the circle.

Call students back into a circle as they have finished the ceremony; having shown the positive expectations they will hold for each other.

Limited follow-up about the ceremony may take place in the circle but is not necessary.

This is a good opportunity to bring together the whole class to let them know that as they go off into the world together, out of these groups, they still have each other.

As students leave an effort should be made to recognize each one of them (handshakes, high fives, eye contact, etc.)

Extensions

If time allows for a celebration suggested activities include:

- Pizza party
- Card game
- Watching a short movie or TV show
- Going on a walk outdoors
- Games in the gym

Assessment

This curriculum was designed assuming the class would be split into gender-specific groups in alternating classes. Here are some project and assessment ideas for the whole class.

Reflections

You could track students' learning by encouraging reflection in the classes between activities. Here are some suggestions for keeping a record of their changing perspectives:

- Journals – students could reflect on the previous activity, offer feedback for the facilitator(s) and describe their initial impressions of the upcoming topic. Students could also keep a record of the anti-anxiety techniques they've tried and any progress they've noticed.
- Discussion forum – students could participate in an online discussion form through the class' Moodle site. You could offer guiding questions or have the students participate in an open discussion. This could help you track the progress of quieter students. It could also give students an opportunity to revisit any comments that were made during the activity.
- Website – This would be similar to the discussion forum but could allow more flexibility for student input. Students could conduct pre- and post-activity interviews on topics such as the expectations of men and women or consent and upload the results as a record of their progress.

Encourage students to relate their experience to as many activities as possible, not necessarily the most recent. The more connections they develop, the better you can assess their application of the material.

Media Critiques

Mass media enforces the pressures of masculinity and femininity. Students could collect video and image advertisements and determine “what's really being sold.” Students could have time between activities to add to their collections and discuss the rationale behind and effects of media that perpetuate exaggerated stereotypes.

As students develop an interest in the project, they could look at more specific issues such as:

- How food is marketed to men vs. women
- What's advertised where (whether certain products or types of products are advertised only in certain neighbourhoods.)
- Whether alcohol advertisements appeal more to teenagers than adults

Students could complete the assignment by creating their own advertisements. They could create “honest” advertising that represents more nuanced representations of people, satirical advertising that is upfront about its reductive representation, etc. The project would be a record of how they're applying the concepts discussed in class.

Assessment

Community Resource Board

Set-up a community resource board/wall in the classroom for students to contribute to as they engage with the Boys & Girls Group material.

Ideas for this resource:

- Encourage students to add to the board at any time, with the expectation that they contribute a specified number of resources throughout the year.
- Encourage students to explore the community resources on the board, adding more information or commenting on the resource.
- After discussing a certain topic in the groups, ask students to find a related health resource and create a visual outlining this resource to be added to the board. Potential topics include alcohol or substance use, mental health, sexual health, violence, etc.
- Discuss which health supports are strong in your community and where there may be gaps in supporting some community health issues. Have students design a pamphlet or commercial for a new health resource that they feel the community would benefit from.
- Emphasize the health resources that are available in their own school community (or in the high school they will attend next year) and invite these key individuals to speak to the class.
- Talk about how they can access these resources and role play what they may expect when they visit or contact a community health resource.

Potential Outcomes

9.17 examine how people support healthy communities locally and globally, and take age appropriate action to support a community health issue of interest to them

9.20 identify school and community-based resources and health services available to assist themselves or a friend if help or information in the area of sexual health, mental health, alcohol and other substance use or gambling is needed, and practice how to make initial contact with such service/resource.

Physical Health Experiment

This assessment could follow the group activity on our bodies and how they age. You could have students design and carry out their own experiment to track how a minor change in their level of physical activity can affect their overall health. Students can select a type of physical activity that they will engage in for five minutes daily, over a month, and collect data to track changes and assess trends. You could give students

Assessment

freedom in their choice of exercise and means of data collection, or have all students participate in the same experiment.

Some ideas may be:

- Students take their resting heart rate and engage in physical activity (running on the spot, jumping jacks or squats) for five minutes. Students would then record their heart rate after exercise.
- Students select a repetitious exercise that challenges them (sit-up's, push-up's, burpees, planks) and track the number they can complete in a five minute period, with breaks if necessary.

After a month, have students graph their results (change in heart rate over time, number completed over time, etc.). Students will likely find there was a gradual increase in their ability/decrease in their heart rate as they progressed, despite the small amount of time dedicated to this activity. Challenges to setting aside this time should also be acknowledged and discussed.

You could extend this assessment to examine healthy eating habits and have students create personal plans/schedules for adapting their diets, emphasizing that even minor changes can have an effect. Set specific nutritional guidelines and challenge the students to design the 'tastiest' meal they can within this criteria. Have students pitch their meals to the class and vote on the meal they would like the most.

Potential Outcomes

9.4 assess level of physical activity to determine whether they are active enough to achieve health benefits and identify time in the day to increase physical activity in 5 to 10 minute periods.

9.5 create a plan that enhances their healthy eating practices and reflects on supportive environments and challenges to achieve these health eating practices.

Design Your Own Neighbourhood

This could be an on-going project for the class, which would enable them to assess their own community and apply what they learn from Healthy Living class in designing their own neighbourhood. Students would start by creating a map and taking an assessment of their own neighbourhood, tracking the types of businesses, food establishments, community resources and outdoor or indoor spaces for physical activity. They may want to compare this to a nearby neighbourhood as a means of assessing how conducive it is to physical activity and how healthy the area is.

Based on this assessment of what is healthy and what may need improvement in their community, let students know they will be designing their own healthy community over the semester as they engage with the curriculum. Students should draft an initial design of their community on a large piece of paper, which

Assessment

will allow for edits as they re-think initial choices as they progress in the semester.

Considerations to point out:

- Placement of businesses and outdoor spaces. Will you allow a liquor store, fast food?
- Do certain businesses, food establishments and design choices send a negative message about how healthy/safe/affluent a neighbourhood is?
- Are certain spaces in a neighbourhood associated with a particular gender? Is this what you want for your neighbourhood? Assess gendered spaces in their own neighbourhood
- Will you allow advertisements and billboards in your community? Will you limit what will be advertised?
- What health resources or supports should be available in a healthy neighbourhood?
- How can you encourage physical activity in different age groups (children, youth, and adults, elderly) through your design?

Toward the end of the year students could present or display their neighbourhoods for the rest of the class to consider. You may want to invite a community designer to consider the design choices and talk about the commonalities between all of the neighbourhoods.

Potential outcomes

9.17 examine how people support healthy communities locally and globally, and take age-appropriate action to support a community health issue of interest to them

9.22 examine how design and infrastructure of the school community and surrounding community enhances or creates barriers to physical activity among youth

9.23 investigate principles of and beliefs around financial health and demonstrate an awareness of the capacity for financial health to positively or negatively affect one's state of health

Simulated Future

This assessment could follow group activity on personal superpowers. Students could work through a simulated future based on their life goals. You could set this up as a long-term project that students revisit and develop on a weekly basis. There is also potential for extension activities from this assessment. Students reflections are an important aspect of this assessment, and you may want to have students complete journal

Assessment

entries with key questions after each phase of the simulation.

Here's how you could set up this assessment activity:

- Begin with a self-assessment survey to help students reflect on their goals. The questions could ask about their post-secondary plans, careers, families, expected income, etc.
- Collect these surveys so they can inform the direction of the simulation. You may also want to have students complete a post-survey at the end of the year to compare their choices.
- Have students research the career they're interested in pursuing, focusing on the realities of a career in this field, including the necessary schooling, cost of schooling and average salary. You may wish to incorporate job shadowing here.
- Give students "Your Future Packages." These can be based on the answers the students gave, but should have some differences. If students planned to start a family, you may want to give students a partner in the class whom they must make decisions with. The package could include: career choice and salary, student loans, insurance type, commute time, number of children. Students could represent this information on a poster, which they would complete as they progress through the year/scenarios they encounter.
- Each week add a new level to the simulation. These could be assessed through the students' simulation poster or journaling. You could do this through:
 - ⇒ Proposing life choices that each student must make based on their situation (e.g. Do you want to buy/rent a car or take a bus; Do you want to purchase a house or rent? Do you want to go on vacation?).
 - ⇒ Having students randomly draw scenarios or issues they encounter and determine their options and the solution that works best for them (e.g. you lose your job, you need dental surgery, your student loan get paid off, your car breaks down, you get a promotion, large tax return or taxes owed).

Extension activities:

- Questionnaires/interview an adult in their life about the topics they are exploring.
- Job-shadow someone who works in the field they're interested in to find out about the career, necessary education and steps they may need to take to prepare themselves for this goal.
- Explore course selection at the high school they're entering. Invite guidance councillors or current students to speak to the students about the courses.

Potential outcomes

9.23 investigate principles of and beliefs around financial health and demonstrate an awareness of the capacity for financial health to positively or negatively affect one's state of health

9.8 develop a plan to acquire the skills and credentials which will lead to their career goals